

Tension-Type Headache Self-Care and Management

Tension-type headache is the most common primary headache disorder, characterized by a dull, aching band-like pain across the forehead or back of the head.

Self-Care & Non-Pharmacological Management: - Stress Management: Cognitive relaxation, biofeedback, and regular physical rest. - Hydration: Maintaining adequate fluid intake throughout the workday. - Posture & Ergonomics: Ensure proper screen height and chair support to prevent neck muscle strain. - Limit Medication Use: Avoid taking acute pain medicines for more than 10-15 days per month to prevent medication-overuse headache (MOH).

Headache Red Flags Requiring Immediate Emergency Referral

Urgent Red Flags (SNOOP Criteria): - Sudden onset severe headache reaching peak intensity within seconds ('thunderclap' headache). - Headache accompanied by fever, stiff neck, confusion, seizure, or focal neurological deficits (weakness, numbness, vision loss). - New headache in patients with history of cancer or immunocompromise. - Headache associated with recent head trauma or worsening with coughing/straining. - Progressive headache worsening over days or weeks in adults over 50.

Migraine Self-Care & Environmental Comfort

Migraine presents as episodic throbbing headache often accompanied by nausea or sensitivity to light and sound. Comfort Measures: - Rest in a quiet, dark room during acute attacks. - Apply a cool cloth or ice pack wrapped in a towel to the forehead or temples. - Maintain regular sleep, meal, and exercise schedules to reduce migraine frequency.

Medication-Overuse Headache Prevention

Frequent use of acute pain medications can cause medication-overuse headache. Prevention Advice: - Track pain medication frequency in a headache diary. - Consult a doctor if acute treatments are needed more than twice a week.